i am the idiot with the painted face (in the corner, taking up space)

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by paststories

Summary

> “I like you.” A flippant remark, sprung out of nowhere after a spar.
>
> His heart seized, then dropped to his stomach.

Phainon and Mydei's confessions over the cycles.

Notes

> this was supposed to be a wifechasing fic but it derailed into whatever it is now. I’ll try for a proper one one day. title is from Mitski's me and my husband!

See the end of the work for more notes

“I like you.”

Out of all the cycles, the first confession is the most vivid. Just before the Eternal Recurrences, before he had to bear the name Khaslana and forge a path forward for an uncertain future.

The sky was beautiful and clear, as it always was, the city was bustling, they were taking a break from sparring, and the world felt *right.*

Back then, Phainon had been naive, though his feelings had not been less intense.

He had given him a wavering smile, or so he thought he did. He couldn’t quite remember his own minute actions, not like he did with Mydei’s.

“I quite like you too, Mydeimos,” he had replied, his trembling fingers belying his nonchalance. “As a… trusted friend and fellow Chrysos Heir.”

Mydei scowled. “HKS, you know that’s not what I meant.”

He swallowed, looking down at the ground. “Forgive me, I…”

“You don’t have to give me an answer, nor am I particularly looking for one.” Mydei turned, face unreadable as he tossed his practice sword back onto the rack before heading to the exit.

A spike of fear slashed through him. Need overwhelmed him. The need to reassure him. The need to ask, *is it okay for me to have these feelings too?* The need to be reassured. Scrambling after him, Phainon just barely caught Mydei’s half-lidded eyes of rejection, his own practice sword clattering loudly on the ground. “*No*, please, I—”

He couldn’t get the words out as fast as he should’ve, panic forcing his hand forward to grasp at Mydei, his voice quiet but pleading. “Please.”

As he counted Mydei’s still heaving breaths, half from their workout, half from something else, slowly, Phainon could hear past the frantic buzzing of his thoughts, could organize feelings he had long tried to bury, could try to attempt to put them into the world despite his ineptness.

“Me too,” he stuttered eventually, the words coming out stilted and strange and not at all how he wanted to say them. “I—I, as well.”

Slowly, something resembling a smile tugged on the corners of Mydei’s lips.

Perhaps it was the most vivid because it was the only time he had accepted it.

The world ended with only him and Cyrene, left only with a tantalizing Era Nova.

Everything rewound.

Not every Eternal Recurrence had a confession.

Though, when there is, he doesn’t know what Mydei sees in his Coreflame-addled form, his body corroding at the edges.

Every time he confesses, though, something in Phainon’s chest stirs, past the thrum of the power coalescing into one, past the blaze in his body, as if trying to remind him of how love felt. Feels.

He can’t remember which Eternal Recurrences Mydei had confessed to him after the Final Era Nova, but there must’ve been some in the earliest ones.

“I like you.” A flippant remark, sprung out of nowhere after a spar.

His heart seized, then dropped to his stomach. The want nearly overwhelmed him, just for a second over the Coreflames, until he remembered to viciously tamp it down.

It wasn't that he didn’t want it. He wanted it so badly — too badly. He wanted it to become real, to feel his fingers card through his hair, be able to wrap his arms around him and share lazy kisses with him without any repercussions, and have them wake together in the morning by filtered sunlight beaming down on them. But they couldn’t. Because he knows how this will end. Because he knew the grief would crush him, and he would still have to move on. To have something and take it away with your own hands was infinitely worse than if he hadn’t had the chance at all.

“I can't," he choked, he begged. “I’m sorry.”

He couldn't look at his trembling lashes, the frozen-over look on Mydei’s face when the words left him.

If Mydei had asked for a reason, a chance, anything, he would’ve given in —horribly. But he doesn’t. He never does. Never asks for a reason and never asks why. He just—

“Okay,” he simply said, neither sharp nor angry. He just accepts it, like he’s already known the answer.

Khaslana would have nearly mistaken it for dismissal, if not for the tenseness of his shoulders he knew to be deep hurt.

Mydei doesn't look back as he leaves.

There was a cycle where he had joined the Kremnoan Detachment before heading straight towards Okhema.

It was fine, he told himself. Mydei would regroup with the Chrysos Heirs in Okhema eventually anyway.

When he saw the soldiers dawning on the horizon, he raised Dawnmaker, stabbing it into the ground.

The Kremonan soldiers are led by the crown prince, and so, Phainon knelt, asking for a duel. When he saw a flicker of curiosity in Mydei’s face, he let out a soft exhale and watched as Mydei jumped off his horse.

Mydei never goes easy on him, and to an extent, he loves that about him. After all, it’s a sign of respect.

But the gentleness that lay in Mydei’s eyes in sleepless nights, the way they spark when they exchange blows, were all too familiar. A confession in itself, of admiration, of camaraderie. Of finally finding an equal. So he left in the dead of night months later, leaving a single note saying he left of his own volition and to not look for him.

Years later, when they faced each other on opposite sides, Khaslana could still see the remnants of the kindness outlining his eyes. Despite it, Mydei remained unimpeded, standing in his way to the Strife Coreflame, as he does in all the cycles before this, and in all the ones after that.

When Mydei wished him eternal victory, as he always does, Khaslana’s lips moved before he registered it, but no noise came out.

Mydei, his lips moved, because he couldn’t put it into sound in fear of reality, as if saying it aloud would bring destruction. *Mydei*.

When he closes his eyes, he dreams of Mydei, his Mydei, the one he stood on opposite sides of Tanlaton’s scales. When Phainon opens his eyes and sees his gritty smirk as he lunges for him in their spars, his soft smiles as he bends down to receive a flower crown from his horde of children, he can't help but fall for him, over and over again across thirty million cycles.

In the deepest parts of his despair, when he could hardly see past the blaze of the Coreflames to look at his comrades' faces, he had called it a curse. For loving this world. For loving its people. For loving Mydei, which has always been as easy as breathing.

But in the end, it's because he loves so ardently that he can drag himself through the cycles, up to his neck with spilt blood. And so, he continues forward.

Somewhere around the four-millionth cycle, Khaslana entrusted his journey to the next cycle's Phainon. Without needing time to go along with the other Chrysos Heirs, it gave him time to observe. To think. To allow his wistfulness to ferment into rage.

He couldn't say the words to Mydei, not when he still looked at whatever Eternal Recurrence's Phainon like he hung the stars in the sky in that quiet way of his, and his own self, the expression mirrored back in his not-so-quiet way. He could not seek out whatever Eternal Recurrence's Mydei, not when the world resides on his shoulders and their fate is what it is.

So Khaslana seeks out his library, a fragile promise made too long ago to remember fully anymore. He trails his fingers over the leather spines. He takes one out, flipping aimlessly through pages he can't see. He can't make out a single word past the Coreflames, but he tries to imagine what Mydei would've given him. *The Evolution of Weaponry* perhaps? Or that

dictionary with little more than *HKS* in it. He tries to imagine it. Spears. Mydei had—*has* a specialty in them, despite his recent use of gauntlets. Swords? Mydei has always matched him in swordplay, even when their duel ended up with them tossing aside their swords and continuing with their fists alongside grins that made passerby steer their children farther away.

He doesn't know when the delicate papers burn in his hands. The very air itself seems to catch fire, then the books around him go up in flames, until all that's left is a raging inferno. It tells him, *this is not your place*, even if he desires it so. It tells him, *you don't belong*, even if he wishes for it and banishes the thought within seconds. It punishes him for even daring to think about it, even when his hands move frantically around him in an attempt to keep the tomes from burning, only to fuel the flames further. It tells him that it is futile, when he's only accompanied by ash.

When Khaslana plunges his blade through Mydei's back, he whispers it back behind a mask to hide his cowardice, for every time he had rejected and all of the times he should've said it, past and future.

I love you, he whispers, when the pads of his fingers, which have all but burned off and gone numb thousands of cycles prior, close Mydei's lifeless eyes and wipe the fine trails of golden blood from his lips.

I love you, he whispers, when he holds Mydei's body close, lifting his mask to press his lips to his hair before warping into a portal.

I love you, he whispers across millions of cycles, like dandelion wisps carried and scattered by wind, delicate and fleeting.

Eternal Recurrence 33,550,336. There are new people around this time.

Refugees? New Chrysos Heirs?

(Did it matter anyway?)

“You call that protecting the citizens? You basically flung that corpse into us!” he hears this cycle’s counterpart of himself arguing.

“I *was,*” Mydei argues back. “And you seem to forget that I flung it, you dodged it, and it hit the ones that were rapidly approaching. So thus, protecting *you.*”

“Okay, but did you have to do it that way? What if someone got hurt?”

He scoffs. “Your friends there seem quite capable, if my eyes worked properly. Didn’t that one—” he jerks his chin to the gray-haired one “—

start beating one of the Titankin into the ground with a mace?”

“...Okay, but the point still stands! What if you tore your muscles?”

“...Then I’d heal?”

The air turns tense. Khaslana dearly wants to step away, but the stench of Nikador still lurks by Okhema.

Then Mydei speaks. “I got thirty badges, by the way. You?”

“...Twenty nine.”

The gray-haired traveler’s eyes drift between the two, mouth agape.

His companion elbows him. “Close your mouth.”

The first one graciously does so before he gestures vaguely in their direction. “So like are you two a thing…? Married for fifty years kind of thing perhaps?”

“What are you talking about?” two voices ask in unison, one nervously trying to laugh it off and the other genuinely confused.

Khaslana looks on, mask apathetic, but the Coreflames rile up inside him like tides surging.

Once again, he goes through the motions of taking the Coreflames. They’ve gotten a lot more, this time around.

Once again, they stand in his way.

The refugees he saw in the beginning are imbued with a strange power, like nothing he’s seen in this world.

Hope swells in his chest when the one they call “Dan Heng” fights him with powers similar to the Ocean Titan. But that can’t be right.

When he’s stopped in his tracks by a higher power, he instinctively knows —

Ah, the heroes beyond the sky have finally come.

When he enters the Vortex of Genesis, he sees that familiar sky, so far yet so close.

They really were close to achieving Era Nova.

His sword moves faster than his flame-addled brain, smoothly lopping off the Antikytheran’s head.

He doesn’t flinch at his counterpart’s bewilderment upon seeing his face when his mask gets caught on the edge of Phainon’s sword, falling to the ground with a metallic *clack*.

He only accepts it when he is defeated, with Dawnmaker piercing his chest. He guides Phainon’s hand to form Cyrene’s ceremonial blade, jerking his hand forward towards his neck.

He can’t remember most of the fight.

He just remembers urging the Trailblazers and Mem, who he has always imagined Cyrene to grow up to look like, to not hesitate, to draw their blade and fight. Wishing them eternal victory for what was to come.

His body flickered as the hatred overtook and eventually shattered him.

The birth of Irontomb was imminent, but somehow past it all…

Khaslana felt a strange sense of peace.

When Phainon wakes, it's to a pink sky marked by an occasional cloud floating by. Dawn has finally ushered in.

The sensations underneath him are familiar; bygone days laying on fields of grass and wheat, napping and playing and skipping Mrs. Pythias's classes.

He looks up at the sky for a few more minutes, counting the clouds as they pass, and nearly dozing off again before he remembers. He jerks upright to look around, unsheathing Dawnmaker.

"Where…"

Not a soul is by his vicinity, but it doesn't seem sinister. In fact, quite the opposite. The air is warm and inviting, sunlight filtering down on him past the leaves of the tree he slept under. It reminds him of Aedes Elysiae in spring.

He rubs the sleep from his eyes as he stands to explore. The rosy buds on the trees remind him of someone's hair. Somewhere deeper in the garden, a wind chime sounds.

Then, the tranquility is broken.

"I found him!" He hears a distant shout.

"Secure!" He hears the same voice, only much closer.

"Capture!" In the next moment, he's soaring in that vast pink sky, wind whistling in his ears, arms held aloft by two redheaded girls. He wonders if he's still trapped in a dream, dreaming of flying like he did when he was younger.

When his brain registers, he flails. "Lady Tribios?"

"Ah! Don't move, Snowy, we're bringing you to the Twilight Courtyard!"

“I’m okay,” he tries to reassure, but they have none of it, their wings steadily beating behind their backs. “What of your Century Gates?”

“They no longer work,” Trinnon says on his left. “We hadn’t had the time to build another rocket yet.”

“But it’s okay,” Trianne says on his right, pretending to struggle with his weight. “It’s safe here! Everyone is.”

His mouth opens and he hesitates before asking quietly, “Is it really?”

“It is.” Tribbie pats his head from above. “It’s over now, Snowy.”

Phainon only remembers feeling the sunlight on his skin as he read under the same tree when he had first awoken in the Eternal Page, looking up occasionally to watch the wind move the clouds.

When he wakes, it’s to children’s laughter and chimera awoos. There’s a shadow over his half lidded eyes, one he belatedly realizes is a hand and turns to look at who it belongs to.

Mydei sits by him, hand shielding the sunlight from his face, as he quietly hushes the children who had taken to petting the chimeras and watching the seals butt heads.

Phainon dozes off again, distantly feeling someone brushing his bangs away from his face. This time, he dreams of children with golden red hair and blue eyes.

Perhaps this is what happiness tastes like.

The Astral Express arrives to check on them some months after the battle, when the peace still feels too uneven, like one stumble can careen the planet back into disarray.

Apparently, that stumble is today, if the stumble was a walking, talking host for something called ‘the cancer of all worlds’.

“Right,” Caelus says, a few days past the banquet to welcome them. “I heard Mydei was getting married? Am I invited?”

Phainon’s smile freezes on his face. The air goes stifling, like when all he could inhale was the smoke of millions of cold flames. “What?”

Caelus frowns, oblivious to his peace shattering three times over. “Oh. I guess it was presumptuous of me to assume I’ll be invited to your wedding since I saved the world. Sorry.”

He claps a hand onto his shoulder. He doesn’t register that his nails are digging into him until Caelus winces. “Partner. *Who* did you say was getting married?”

He looks down at Phainon’s hand, then back at his face. “Uh… Mydei?”

“To *who?*” He tries to ignore the desperation leaking into his voice.

“I thought… you…” Caelus’s mouth gapes like a fish out of water when he puts together the pieces. “It’s not you?”

Slowly, he shakes his head.

The look he receives is utter pity, like he’s a puppy in a flimsy cardboard box that was caught in the rain. “Oh, *Phainon.*…”

“Never mind who it is.” He starts pacing as restless energy fills him. “Why is he getting married?”

“What do you mean why? Can’t a man settle down after the entire cosmos almost got obliterated?”

A crystal tears out of Phainon’s shoulder, piercing through his layers. Valiantly, his wings don’t burst out of his back to join it. Caelus wipes the sweat under his chin when blistering heat flares out in waves. “*Partner*.”

“Sorry, sorry. I’m also not too sure on the deets, but I overheard it’s a political thing. Something about making an heir.” Caelus blinks. “I don’t want to startle you, but your hair is smoking.”

Phainon impatiently pats down his hair. “Making an heir? Not just get married?”

“Don’t shoot the messenger. Why don’t you ask the man himself? You know, since—”

“I can’t.” Phainon wrings his hands restlessly. “If I ask Mydei—”

“Ask me what?”

Phainon doesn’t turn immediately at the familiar voice, shooting a desperate look at the Trailblazer.

“...since the person himself is behind you,” Caelus finishes indignantly. Never has Phainon wanted to shake someone by the shoulders as much as he wants to at this moment. Lovingly, of course, but enough to make the two brain cells remaining in that head to rattle around audibly.

“Mydei, haha. Um—”

“So what’s up with the dealio about you getting hitched?” Caelus interrupts, and pauses. He then starts vigorously fanning himself with his hand.

“It’s just the ceremony,” Mydei says slowly, giving Phainon a strange look.

“Erm.” Caelus chews his lip. “Still, that’s… sweet!”

The two stare at Phainon, who has yet to contribute to the conversation.

Caelus silently points at his head, grimacing.

Phainon pats down his hair again. He thought he heard a sizzling noise. “Congratulations.”

The look Mydei gives him is odd, almost stilted. “Thank you.”

“Please excuse me,” he mutters under his breath. “Aglaea was looking for me earlier.”

“Deliverer,” Mydei calls, after he has only taken a step. Phainon turns back to look at him, despite it all. He looks a little uncertain. “We’re getting married near the plaza.”

“Yes,” he says placidly. The smile he plasters over his face feels like it can crumble at any second. “I know.”

“Lord Phainon,” Castorice says, after the fifth time his flower crown has fallen apart in his lap. “Are you… alright?”

He shrugs, restarting. “The cosmos are still intact and everyone’s still alive. I’m doing fantastic.”

She frowns. “That’s a rather low bar.”

“How’s Polyxia?”

“She’s doing great…” She furrows her brows. “Wait, don’t change the subject. Are you doing well? Mentally speaking.”

“...Fine.”

“How’s Lord Mydei doing?”

He doesn’t ask her why she asked *him* of all people, instead of, you know, the actual person. “Fine. I think. I think his immortality makes him more reckless, though. He’s still treating himself like he can come back from the dead.”

She nods. “I understand. I also subconsciously avoid touch, though it’s a bad habit. These things take some time.”

“He’s—no, I think that he’s being a little… reckless with his actions too.” He cringes when the words leave his mouth. He definitely could’ve worded that better. “Okay, Mydei’s not the type to be reckless with that kind of stuff. He actually overthinks a lot, but like—”

Castorice blinks. “Sorry, I thought we were talking about his physicals? Like spars, and stuff.”

He deflates. “That too, but…”

“Wait…” She narrows her eyes. “Is this about Lord Mydei’s engagement rumor?”

Phainon feels the sweat starting to bead at the back of his neck. “Well… I’m not denying that it’s not about that—”

“It’s *true?*” A beam starts to spread across her face, and he gets an extremely bad feeling.

“Yes,” he replies faintly.

“Oh my gosh,” she gushes. “Congratulations!”

Oh no.

Oh no, no, *no*.

“It’s…” He swallows past the lump in his throat, “not me.”

“Hm?” She suddenly goes very, very still. *Shit*. “Would you mind elaborating?”

“The one Mydei is marrying—Cas, it isn’t me,” he says helplessly.

“I—okay, calm down,” she says; he doesn’t know if it’s for him or for herself. “You’re saying Lord Mydei is getting married. To… who exactly?”

“I don’t *know*.” The petals nearly turn into juice in his hands. He takes a deep breath. “Sorry. This whole affair has me on edge.”

“Okay,” she says slowly. “Okay. Are you *sure* he’s marrying someone? Positively?”

“He literally couldn’t have said, ‘yes, I’m getting married and it isn’t you’ more clearly than he had. I *wish* I was hallucinating the entire thing.” He fiddles his cape, turning the fabric over and fabric between his fingers until they’re nearly tangled. “Yes, I have a witness. It’s *Caelus*, believe it or not. He was the one who asked Mydei.”

“I see.” She hesitates. “Are you… planning to go to the wedding?”

The laugh catches in his throat like phlegm, forcing an ugly sound out of him. “You’d think he’d appreciate someone who wishes that the aforementioned wedding wasn’t happening at all to be there?”

“I can’t deny that, but,” she says as her eyes well up with sympathy. “You know he’ll want you there, right?”

“Even if he did tolerate me, his… *spouse* wouldn’t.” He spits the word out like venom, nearly vibrating with hate. Then, he catches himself, and slouches in defeat. “I just… I feel like if I go, I won’t be able to wish him a happy marriage. And if I don’t, Mydei might hate me forever.” His laugh breaks when he corrects himself. “He wouldn’t. But he’ll be disappointed, and his disappointment is even worse than his anger. I don’t want to ruin his wedding when it should be the happiest day of his life.”

“Okay.” She finishes her crown, placing it onto his head. He looks up at her through his lashes. “Why do you think you’re frustrated over this?”

He blinks at her. “Frustrated?”

“Aren’t you?” Castorice sweeps a hand over the flowers next to her. They seem to bloom under her touch, petals arching up to meet her palm. “Let me be blunt for a moment, Lord Phainon. Technically speaking, Lord Mydei’s marriage has nothing to do with you. So why are you concerning yourself over it?”

“He’s… someone who knows me inside out. Someone who rips out the ugly parts of me that I try to hide and bottle up, and tells me to face my challenges properly. And I hate that I can’t be someone like that for him. Or if I am, I won’t be anymore.” He fidgets with the grass next to him. “I hate that there’s going to be someone closer to him than I’ll ever be.”

She stares. “Are you saying that it should be you in that place?”

He stares back, cogs clicking in his head. Someone else by Mydei’s side as they spar, lighting the same spark of competitiveness in Mydei’s eyes whenever *they* sparred. Someone else by Mydei’s side as they walk around the plaza together, ordering their usuals as they sit at *their* usual table in Marmoreal Diner. Someone else who will know Mydei more than Phainon could ever. He gets a violent wave of nausea. “No. I can’t. Shouldn’t.”

Castorice narrows her eyes. “You don’t want him to get married, yet you yourself don’t wish to wed him?”

“I do,” he says, defeated. “I want to live together and measure his finger for rings when he’s asleep. I want to look at him and be able to call him my husband. I want everything he has to offer, because I want to offer all that I have to him. But I’m okay with what we have now. Or, at least, I have to be. We’re back to our old routines, and for the sake of both of us, this should be how it is. Is there a reason for it to change if only I want it, no matter how vehement?”

“Lord Phainon,” she says in disbelief. “Did you not perhaps, at any point in time, think that Lord Mydei harbors the same sentiments as you?”

He gives her an exhausted smile. “He couldn’t possibly.”

How could he? After having spilt everyone’s blood so many times, the very act of being able to be near them in the Eternal Page was enough for him.

He could make flower crowns for Castorice and her sister. He could model for Aglaea’s shop. He could help Tribios, as she’s slowly forming back into one, think of new ways to improve their rocket. He could spend the day organizing documents with Hyacine for Professor Anaxa.

And to Mydei, who has entrusted his weak spot to him in each and every cycle, who has invited him to his library despite the possibility of ruin, who has never doubted him even when they stood on opposing sides.

How could Mydei return his feelings despite everything he had done to him?

That is why Phainon could not allow these feelings to develop further, for the reason he would take more than he could ever return, because it always happened that way. He used Mydei’s weak spot to fuel the Coreflames. The Library of Garbaniphoro had always burnt down despite his wishes—no, *because* of his wishes. The trust between them had become a shackle, a constant reminder that he was attempting a Sisyphean feat.

He couldn’t trust himself with the possibility of twisting that trust and destroying it with his hands once again.

“Then, have you ever made these sentiments known to him?” She interrupts him sharply when he opens his mouth. “With actual, confirmational words. Not just by following him around.”

“...I haven’t.”

“Then how, pray tell, would you know his feelings, and he yours?” Castorice sighs. “Lord Phainon. I don’t want you to think we blame you for the Eternal Recurrences because that is perhaps the farthest from the truth. It is only because you endured for our sake that we are allowed this peace. I do not think that Lord Mydei blames you either. However, I don’t think that he knows of these feelings… for better or worse.”

“And he shouldn’t.”

“Who is that going to help?” she shoots back.

He gestures vaguely. “Everyone. In the long run.”

“I’m getting deja vu.” She starts on another flower crown. “You know, there’s something you haven’t tried yet.”

“Right.” He fidgets with the flower crown on his head. “I think I’ve tried just about everything but outright confessing.”

“Communication,” she says, her voice tinged with exasperation. “Try to communicate with him about your feelings.”

He wilts. “Wouldn’t it be horrible to do that to a guy who’s due to marry soon? Why should I burden him with my feelings? It would be best to take it to the grave.”

“Frankly speaking, I don’t think you’re fooling anyone,” she mutters. “You needn't be so direct. Since apparently no one knew he was getting married, much less the person he is marrying, you can ask a little about that. It doesn’t have to be as direct as confessing.”

He softens. “Yeah. Okay. Thanks, I’ll try.”

She gives him a faint smile, tentatively bringing up her arms, and he circles his around her body.

She’s warm.

“Mydei,” he asks, in the quiet of the baths. He had always dragged out Mydei for one, even when the man was napping. Mydei never protested when he felt his arms slinging over someone’s back and his legs hefted and secured by strong arms. Today doesn’t change from every other day’s routine, down to when Phainon carries him on his back, pretending to be unaffected when he feels Mydei’s soft, half-asleep breaths on the side of his neck. “Are you happy?”

Mydei blinks sleepily at him. His head doesn’t rise from where he rests against the edge of the pool, but his lips curve up slightly. “Yes,” he murmurs, in the same voice he reserves for the children. “Very.”

Contrary to Castorice’s advice, he spends the next month avoiding Mydei.

It isn’t that he wants to. He’s completely miserable in fact, having not seen hide nor hair of him since Mydei had confirmed he was getting married. He hasn’t taken out Mydei for a bath since that day either, so if something didn’t seem off before, something did now.

Which is probably how it landed him into this situation.

The situation being cornered against a wall with Mydei's gauntleted fingertips two inches away from clawing out his throat.

He had just been walking from the Marmoreal Market when he had been inexplicably yanked into an alleyway, still lit by the setting sun, though out of eyesight from the general public. He had nearly pulled out Dawnmaker before he registered the amber eyes and flame tipped hair.

"Deliverer." Mydei says. "We need to talk."

"Of course," Phainon says amicably, like he hasn't been avoiding this man for a month and about to reap the consequences of his own actions. "Whatever you want."

"You said you wanted to come visit my library." His mouth is twisted down, eyes accusatory. "And that you wanted me to try the grape pies from Aedes Elysiae. And that you wanted to introduce your parents to me. Are you taking back your word?"

"No!" he says, gesturing frantically as his facade rapidly fades. "Of course not. The offer still stands, but perhaps the timing would be better after the… wedding." His own parents mistaking Mydei as his betrothed might just be the final nail in the coffin. Then, he sees the frustration underlying the accusation and immediately folds. "But if there's anything I can do in the meantime that I can do to make up for it, then…"

Mydei stares, then releases him. "Dance with me."

“I—” Phainon can only helplessly follow him with his gaze when Mydei steps aside to unclasp his cape. “Pardon?”

“I haven’t had the time to practice for the ceremony, but I assume we’d need to dance at some point.” He extends a hand out to him, lifting his chin like he’s daring him to refuse. If he did, he wouldn’t put it past Mydei to try and gut him. “Better now than never.”

“But—” Phainon bites down on his lip. *But why are you asking me instead of your betrothed? Did they not even want to, with you? But—* He shuts down the thought before his brain can continue it. “If that’s what you desire.”

He takes Mydei’s hand, and Mydei pulls him closer until they’re almost chest to chest.

“Wait, you’re going to dance with those on?” Phainon jerks his head at the gauntlets. “Do you want to gouge the bones out of my hands or something?”

He lifts a brow, challenging him. “Do you mind?”

Phainon swallows and says weakly, “I may not, but your spouse might.”

Mydei pauses. Then starts withdrawing his hands from Phainon's grip.

Before he could fully extract himself, Phainon grasps his hands again. "I don't mind! I really don't, so…" *So don't get stolen away by someone who doesn't even want to practice dancing with you.*

Mydei huffs. "I wasn't going anywhere. I was just going to unfasten my gauntlets."

They hold their gazes for a short, tense moment with intertwined fingers and breaths, before Phainon's hands go slack and Mydei steps back to free his gauntlets, placing them by his cape.

"That being said," Mydei says, turning back to him. "Do you even know how to dance?"

"Aglaea taught me a few in the case I need to attend an event that requires it." He takes Mydei's hand, brushing his lips over the back. "Though, I can't say the same about you."

He narrows his eyes. Phainon suppresses a smile. This seems more like them, right? "You haven't even seen me try, HKS. I have had no need to. However, I'll have you know I'm well acquainted with traditional Kremnoan dances."

“Oh? Do show, my dear Mydeimos.”

He’s unprepared for the kick Mydei launches at his throat, but he dodges on instinct anyway.

The smug glimmer in Mydei’s eyes is all that he needs to see before Phainon loosens the fabric that his cape hangs off of and pulls it between them like a curtain.

He takes the chance he gets from the distraction, lunging for him. Traitorously, he feels a grin start to grow on his face.

Mydei ducks, batting aside his arm, and goes for a jab. But something odd happens. The second Phainon braces for the hit, Mydei stops. Not freezes, because Phainon moves to counter his attacks, but stops the blow from connecting.

Perhaps it’s a fluke. Mydei isn’t the type, but a feint isn’t out of the question.

It happens four more times before he finally recognizes it. The reason why Mydei hadn’t landed any hits on him, even though by now he would’ve gained several new bruises.

This was the dance in question.

Phainon finds himself slowing down, matching Mydei's tempo. He stops aiming to win, starts taking slower moves to show off to a nonexistent audience.

Mydei being Mydei, notices it. The smirk he gives Phainon is somewhere between *Took you long enough* and *I knew you'd get it*.

They continue; the closest they get to touching is brushing the other's fabric with their fingernails. Phainon's restraint comes close to snapping a few times, but their dance is a combination of their usual sparring and Phainon dancing the way Mydei maneuvers his body, so when he comes too close, Mydei would sidestep, foot kicking his shin as a warning.

So Phainon decides to fight back, though one could say his way was… unconventional. He slows down himself further, no longer keeping up.

When Mydei frowns but eventually charges for him anyway, Phainon veers to the side, faster than the dance had been and his usual sparring tactics. Before Mydei can adjust, his hand comes.

His fingers are gentler than he expected from himself when he brushes aside a lock of hair from Mydei's lips, tucking it behind his ear. It hangs a bit past his collarbones now, though he still hasn't bothered tying it back besides his usual braid.

It takes him a second to realize that Mydei has stopped moving altogether, save for his breathing, and that he's staring at Phainon like he's grown a second head.

"Your hair's getting longer," he says pathetically in the silence.

Mydei narrows his eyes before slowly saying, "I'm aware."

"Right," Phainon breathes as he draws back. "Of course you are, because it's on your head."

Mydei's quiet for a moment before scoffing lightly and moving to pick up Phainon's cape.

Anxious to not let their time together end, Phainon asks, "Want me to show you how Okhemans dance?"

Mydei looks on impassively before putting the cloak aside with his own belongings. "Yes. That's the whole reason we're here."

He clears his throat and holds out his hand, mirroring Mydei's previous action. "Then… may I have the honor of having this dance?"

With a calm expression, Mydei gives him his hand, wiping the sweat under his chin with the other. It's surprisingly soft.

Phainon sighs, fond. "Let's have an arm wrestling contest again, Mydei. Even after the wedding."

"Okay." Indulging him yet again, no matter which way the wind blows.

(Oh, how Phainon adores this man.)

With one hand on Mydei's waist and the other clasped with his, they start swaying to an imaginary beat.

It's nothing like the fast paced, mock battle from before. While the previous felt like an extension of their spars, this felt a little too… intimate. (Phainon could argue that their spars are, in fact, intimate as well. He doesn't know how many people would agree, though.)

With their bodies pressed against one another like this, he doesnt't know whether the heartbeat he's feeling is his or Mydei's. (It has to be his. Mydei's expression is too even.) Contrary to before, where Mydei had led him, from his footwork to which blows would almost land and which would not, Phainon guides him. In his arms, Mydei is pliant; his steps are light, never crossing over Phainon's. This way, he forgets the rigid *one, two* Aglaea had taught him, spinning and twisting across the ground. It's not like there's other people here to bump into anyway. They dance like they're the last people on the planet.

Phainon couldn’t help but say something, anything to ease the atmosphere. It felt too electrifying, like one wrong spark, one misstep, and their relationship would turn, for better or for worse. He doesn’t know if he wants to find out, but he isn’t taking any chances.

So, he turns to the only thing he knows how to do when the silence gets too loud: goading. “I thought you would be a lot stiffer than this, but it seems not.”

It works, with the way Mydei relaxes slightly and deliberately steps on his toes. “With the way you handle me on a daily basis, I would be tense all day if I didn’t learn how to not be.”

“Then it appears I’m not needed.” He smiles, even when his hand on Mydei’s waist betrays him by tightening. “You might have more favorable results if you find a different partner.”

The hand on Phainon’s shoulder goes imperceptibly tauter when he swings their bodies around. “You are taking back your word?”

“I am not,” he placates as he twirls them in an arc. “I am simply saying you might be better off practicing with someone who isn’t me, or at least someone who you might not be as accustomed to touching.”

“I do not wish for another partner.”

Phainon nearly trips over himself when the words land. *Oh.*

"So I will not go." Mydei's eyes are steady, as is his footwork. "There is no one else I want to practice with."

The silence, save for the clack of their shoes against the tiles, tenses into something more charged, even more than before. Their breaths mingle on occasion when one of them leans in too close, but they do not meet in the middle, pulling back just before they touch.

So of course Phainon has to ruin it. "So," he says. Castorice's voice rings loudly in his head. *Communicate*. "Who's the lucky person?"

Mydei frowns. He isn't quite angry, more so confused. "Lucky person?"

He wants to pull away with the amount of sweat starting to accumulate on his hands. "The one you're marrying? Your… betrothed."

With the way Mydei suddenly digs his heels in to stop and grips his hand and shoulder like he wants to crush them, Phainon knows he has said something wrong, but which part? Mydei's gaze grows fiery. "*What?*"

He swallows. *Communicate.* “Your spouse,” he tries to clarify, even when the words dig into his throat, attempting to stop him. “Or future spouse, I guess.”

“Are you serious?” Mydei’s gaze is positively murderous. “*You* are asking who my husband will be?”

Husband.

Mydei’s husband.

The word splashes over Phainon like he’s just been doused with water, breaking his tentative hope that maybe, just maybe, that communication would work.

“…Haha.” Phainon has half a second to shoot a panicked grin at Mydei’s increasingly incensed glare before ripping his hands away and bolting away at top speed.

“Do you think he liked me? Objectively speaking.”

Caelus and Dan Heng are sitting across from him, having taken him out to eat honeycakes when they had seen him lurking on the rooftops, moping. Except now, he's no longer moping on the rooftops and instead moping in a restaurant, courtesy of the Traliblazers.

"In the previous cycle, I mean. What did our relationship look like to you guys?"

Caelus sets down his fork, looking ill at the mere thought of it. "Is that a serious question?"

Phainon buries his head in his arms. Perhaps he shouldn't have asked.

"Dude, I've *been* knowing. I think everyone has, except maybe the people actually involved." A pause. "That includes you, by the way."

He peeks out of the crook of his elbow at a cough, and sees Caelus looking dramatically out the window. Huh. It seems to only be raining at the exact window he's looking out of. Is Dan Heng indulging him again?

"There was a mission," Caelus begins, eyes telling of a faraway tale. "We were on the road to Castrum Kremnos. Us—the bros, the squad, the threesome—we were on a mission to conquer a Titan."

“Please don’t say threesome,” Dan Heng says absently, not looking up from his book. Though, under the table, his tail snakes back around and wraps loosely around Caelus’s ankle, and neither of them say anything about it, like it’s a normal occurrence. Phainon wants to *die.*

“I remember,” he says instead, miserable. “I left Mydei on the battlefield to fight a corrupted Nikador by himself.”

“Yeah, well.” He scrapes off a corner of his honeycakes before pensively popping it into his mouth. “Not to insult you or him or anything, but I felt like I was one of the pieces of debris on the ground that you guys had that competition for kicking the longest. At some point I was wondering if you guys even remembered I was there.”

“He’s getting married.” Phainon buries his head into his arm. “And then he’ll have debris-kicking competitions with his spouse and then he’ll associate debris-kicking with his spouse and not *me*—”

“Phainon,” Caelus interrupts, exaggeratingly solemn, and he tries his best to meet his friend’s energy. When Dan Heng finally looks up, albeit to give him a look of mild concern, he knows he failed. “Why do you think that you were the first person I thought Mydei was marrying?”

“Because we look good together?” he tries hopefully.

“No.” He points his fork triumphantly at the ceiling. “It’s because, that day, you truly taught me what it meant to be a part of the floor.”

The Chrysos Heirs begin preparing for the wedding. With every decoration, with every plan, Phainon dreads the actual wedding day more and more.

When he sees Trianne and Trinnon hanging banners, he can't find it in himself to do much but pass over the streamers when they reach for him on occasion.

Tribbie pulls him aside halfway through, ignoring his feeble protests. Putting her hands on her hips, she squints up at him. "Be honest, Snowy. Have you been avoiding De?"

He stills. "What makes you say that?"

"He was looking for you earlier. He said that you were going to help him with something." She frowns. "It isn't like you to break your promises like that."

"He probably wanted to practice dancing some more." He fidgets. "It isn't that grand of a promise."

“Yes,” she says, her eyes uncharacteristically serious. “That’s why it’s concerning.”

When Aglaea beckons him over to take his measurements, he gets several reminders to lift his arms and a raised brow for his inattentiveness.

“Is the wedding ceremony really affecting you to this extent?” she murmurs, and Phainon cannot do anything but look at the ground in shame. She stares at him blankly for a few seconds in a fit of rare speechlessness before wrapping her tape measure around his wrist.

A few minutes go by before she deems her measurements well enough and pats him on the shoulder, signaling his dismissal. Just before he leaves though, she sends him a knowing smile. “Mydeimos is in the other room, by the way. He’s all dolled up, if you wish to check on him. I’m just about finished here anyway, so I’ll be in my office if you need anything.” She turns back to her mannequin, oblivious to the turmoil the words roiled up.

The curiosity eats away at him like a parasite. Mydei? Dolled up? Mydei is *never* dolled up.

With a tentative knock and a soft, “Come in”, he pushes open the door with his fingertips.

Castorice is talking to him quietly, eyes landing on Phainon when he enters. Mydei’s back is half turned. He bends down slightly to receive a flower from her. A lily.

Aglaea's clothes fit him like a glove. The white chiton drapes elegantly over his body, and the red himation lined with gold compliments his eyes and hair. His usual braid is plaited against his scalp with a half updo, the rest of his hair cascading lightly down his shoulders, framing his face. His hair has gotten longer these days. The lily Castorice had given him is tucked behind his ear and he's wearing the necklace and earring Phainon had gifted him years ago, the sapphires inlaid in them matching Phainon's eyes.

He looks ethereal. And he could never be Phainon's.

Phainon walks straight back out the door, and sinks to the floor. "What the hell am I doing…"

"What *are* you doing?" Twintails bouncing, and a familiar creature's chirp.

"…Hyacine." He greets her as she pokes her head into the room, nodding at the two inside, then closes the door.

"Everyone's preparing for the wedding." She nudges him with a foot. "What are you doing here all by your lonesome?"

Little Ica flits lower to sit on his lap, and he tries not to wheeze when he picks it up to cuddle it closer. "Just moping. My usual."

She snorts before plopping down next to him. “Your usual? Your usual consists of hovering over Mydei like an especially anxious guard dog.” She looks him up and down. “Which. You aren’t doing, so something’s off. Spill.”

“I…” He looks away. “He’s getting married.”

“Right.” Hyacine fixes her hat. “So I’ve noticed.”

He gives her a weak smile. “Do we have any idea who the lucky guy is?”

“I’m not sure, either.” She stretches out her legs, her sides of her toes rhythmically tapping against each other. “Though, I must say, for it to be hidden for this long, I wonder if it’s someone from before he joined the Flame Chase.”

Ah. The Kremnoan Detachment, maybe. He struggles to remember the cycle he had deviated from Okhema for a while and joined the Detachment, but all he can come up with are blurry faces and the scorching feeling of his veins on fire.

He deflates. “Maybe.”

She hums. “You’re taking this better than I thought.”

“Am I?” He turns to look at her.

“No.” She looks back at him. “You look kind of miserable, actually. But you aren’t storming around looking for the betrothed in question and instead just sitting around moping about it, so—” She shrugs. “A step above.”

He exhales. “I wouldn’t do that. Unless his partner was a good for nothing.” Which he was leaning towards.

“Right,” she drawls. “What makes you think they aren’t? We don’t even know who they are.”

“If Mydei wants to keep their identity hidden for now, then we hardly have any place to say otherwise.”

“...You say that, but your hair is on fire.”

He impatiently pats his hair down. Always giving his feelings away.

Hyacine heaves a sigh. “Well, he’s probably going to be way busier post wedding too, so no girls night for a while, huh…” She turns to him. “How are you feeling about it?”

“His marriage?” he asks, even when he already knows the answer.

She gives him the Look.

He blows his bangs out of his eyes. “There’s nothing to be angry over. Technically, anyway. It’s Mydei’s decision. I have to respect it.”

“Feelings don’t always go with what’s technical, for your information.” He buries his face into Little Ica’s fur, feeling the vibrations as Little Ica chirps disapprovingly.

“Even if I were hypothetically angry at it, there’s nothing I can do about it this late,” he mumbles.

“Really?” Her voice probes him. “If this continues, will you truly not regret anything?”

Phainon imagines, for a moment, Mydei. His smile. His gruff, honest to a fault exterior. The way he goes along with Phainon’s whims, the way he tempers Phainon all the same.

It wouldn’t be the same after this, would it?

A wing claws its way out of his back and through his clothes, positively ruining Aglaea’s handiwork. Hyacine’s head snaps up to look at him as he tries desperately to fold the appendage back into his spine.

She gapes at him. Even Little Ica’s wings stop fluttering.

“Sorry,” he stammers. The threads are getting mixed with his blood. Aglaea’s going to be *pissed*. “I—Sorry, I don’t know what got into me—”

“Are you alright?” Hyacine rises to her knees, gingerly turning him so his back faces her. He hears her sharp inhale. “We might need to get to the clinic for this one.”

“It’s fine.”

“I can see your bones,” she informs him firmly. She sounds like she’s about to smack him, if it wasn’t for his injury. “Parts of your muscles are quite literally still on your wings. Though I’m not aware of the specifics on how your wings work, you are making a puddle of blood on the floor. Get up.”

“Seriously, Hyacine, it’s fine.” The wings finally tuck themselves back in, his body sewing itself back up. He chances a glance behind him. “See?”

Hyacine looks like she’s about to puke. She has a smear of his blood on her cheek where his wing had flicked it off just before entering back into him. “You being a medical miracle makes perfect sense and none simultaneously. Just be glad Professor Anaxa isn’t here to witness this.”

He fumbles around his back. Yep. A large bloodstained wing sized hole greets his fingers. “I should go to Aglaea. Er, maybe I should soak my shirt for a while first. You…”

“I’m going to help Cassie prepare.” She inexplicably looks much more drained than she did in the beginning of their conversation. Nonetheless, she reaches up to rap him on the head. “Don’t overthink too much in the meantime. Be more honest with yourself.”

“...Thanks for everything, Hyacine.”

“Thanks?” She gives him a tired grin. “There’s no need. I didn’t do anything. Not anything new, anyway.”

“Just in general. For hearing me out.”

She softens. “Come by for tea sometime. We could always use your company.”

Phainon has just changed and is walking through the Garden of Life to get to Aglaea’s office when someone yanks him by the back of his collar and all but throws him into a nearby shrub.

It feels like deja vu.

“Deliverer.”

The Lance of Fury, the Champion of Strife, the greatest conqueror, the mightiest protector, the strongest of them all.

“...Mydei.”

Mydei’s mouth is set into a tight, frustrated line, eyes blazing with restrained rage. “*Talk* to me.”

Phainon opens his mouth, but nothing comes out. What *could* he say? ‘Sorry I’ve been avoiding you, I was trying to run away from my feelings and every time I see you I can’t help but love you and so it breaks me when I remember you’re getting married to someone who isn’t me?’

Mydei lowers his eyes. “Have I disappointed you in some way?”

“No!” He shakes his head immediately. “No, you could never.”

“Then… is this about the ceremony?”

Phainon feels the blood drain out of his face. No matter how badly he didn’t want Mydei to get married, the worst thing that could happen was if Mydei called it off because of *him*.

So he shakes his head again. “No. It’s—I’m just working through some issues right now. Some personal ones.”

Mydei frowns, forehead wrinkling. Phainon aches to smooth it out. “Deliverer—”

“Your Highness, Mister Deliverer!”

They turn to a gaggle of children racing their way over to them.

“Kids,” Phainon breathes a sigh of relief.

“We‘ll discuss this further later,” Mydei says under his breath, voice laced with a threat.

Phainon quickly kneels. “What’s up?”

“Is it true Lord Mydei’s getting married?”

Aglaea’s office isn’t that far of a walk from here, right? He’s always been slightly ahead in cardio compared to Mydei, so perhaps he could outrun him.

“I am indeed taking part in the ceremony soon,” Mydei says, and Phainon looks away, not wanting the others to see the look on his face.

Andriskos deflates. “Does that mean you won’t have time to play with us anymore?”

Mydei pats his head. “It means I may get a bit busier, but I’ll still find time for you all. Is there anything you want to do right now?”

“Ah, I know!” Iris snaps her fingers. “The storyteller in the baths was talking about this play where the main character tries to marry into this family for information about a series of murders…”

“Just what stories are they telling in the baths…”

“Let’s play pretend with that as the base then!”

“Lord Mydei should be the person the main character tries to marry,” Andriskos pipes up. “Since His Highness is getting married, why don’t we play the bad in-laws? It’ll be like practicing how to deal with them.”

“Hey, hey,” Phainon protests. “Why Mydei? If anything, shouldn’t I be the one the main character is supposed to marry? Didn’t you want to help him practice against his horrible in-laws?”

Demetri looks at him like he’s stupid. “What do you mean why? It *is* practice. So Lord Mydei will learn what *not* to do.”

“He also makes yummy snacks!” Marsyas chimes in. “The main character’s partner is a really good chef.”

“The quickest way to someone’s heart is through their stomach.” Livia nods. “No one says no to good food.”

“Yeah! And then Mister Deliverer can be the main character trying to get everyone’s blessings!”

“Kids.” He suddenly feels sick. “I can’t. That’s not right.”

Livia tilts her head. “Why not?”

“Because—”

“I’m alright with it,” Mydei lifts his chin. “Don’t tell me the mighty Deliverer won’t even play house with a couple of children?”

“I will, I just don’t understand why it has to be this scenario…” Phainon nudges him and lowers his voice. “Are *you* sure you want to do this?”

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “I have no qualms about it. It’s just playing house, as I said.”

“But your—okay, fine, whatever you guys say goes,” he sighs. “How are we doing this?”

The children line up, sporting smiles that look too bright to be smug. “Try to get our blessings to marry His Highness!”

“I’ve…come to ask for your blessings to marry your child,” Phainon starts, unsure, eyes flitting to Mydei’s face, which remains impassive. This much was okay, right?

The children squeeze in between the two, creating a tiny wall.

“Ha!” Marsyas crosses his arms. “How bold! You’d think we’d let Lord Mydei marry you?”

“Yes. I—” He clears his throat. “I’m in love with him, and I wish to marry him—”

“You don’t have what it takes!” Demetri mimes slamming a table. “First of all, can you even take care of him? Can you cook?”

He nods. For all Mydei’s grousing about how he could only make salads, he never complained when actually eating them.

“Can you clean?”

He nods again. His quarters are usually pretty neat; the only times when it's especially cluttered is when he comes back from missions.

"Can you promise to make him happy everyday?"

"I'll try my best to make sure he's happy, whether it's something new or old," he promises solemnly. Even if Mydei is currently pissed at him.

"Well…" Demetri turns to look at his companions.

Andriskos sniffs haughtily. "Why would you think we'll allow His Highness to marry someone like you?"

He raises a brow at the title. "His Highness?"

"B-because His Highness is so precious to us, we call him His Highness! He's like royalty to us!"

"I see." He shoots a cheeky smile, momentarily forgetting his internal crisis. "Perhaps I'm closer to him then? As I call him *Mydei*."

The children collectively gasp, a mixture between scandalized and indignant, and over their heads, Mydei reaches out to flick his forehead.

“Dear.” Phainon ignores the tinge of exasperation and instead focuses on the endearment. “Aren’t you supposed to be asking for their blessings and not riling them up?”

“Ah, right.” He clears his throat. “Will you allow me the honor to become a part of your family?”

“After what you just said?” Marsyas fumes. “No way!”

“I’ll give up my life for him if need be!”

Mydei scoffs. “I quite like your life intact, thank you.”

His cheeks grow rosy. “I’ll do my best to let it continue to stay intact then.”

Andriskos points. “No flirting in front of the family!”

“Yeah, Phainon,” Livia pouts. “No one likes to be a third wheel, a fourth wheel, or a whatever wheel. Points off!”

“So we’re never giving you that information now.” Iris crosses her arms.

“Your Highness.” Demetri turns to him. “No offense, but what do you even like about him?”

“Well…” Mydei plays with his braid. “I admire his strength, as I can trust him to have my back. I love his kindness, as he puts others ahead of himself, even if it’s often to his detriment. He treats me well, and he makes me very happy. He is my equal.”

When everyone, including Phainon, gapes at him, Mydei tilts his head. “Was that not enough?”

“That’s quite enough.” Phainon covers his face with his hand. He doesn’t need a mirror to know that his cheeks are pink. “Any more flattering and I’ll be buried in the fields to be grown as a tomato. In a few months, there’ll be mini mes popping up all over the place.”

“It wasn’t flattery.” Mydei turns away, seemingly appeased. “And that last part doesn’t even make any sense.”

Iris glares up at Phainon. “Anyway, even if His Highness is… fond of you, it means nothing if you don’t have our blessings.”

“We will elope,” he says, very seriously.

“*Phainon*,” Mydei hisses.

“Mister Deliverer, I think you've got it all wrong,” Andriskos says gravely. “*We* hold the information you need. Even if you elope, you’ll be out of a job! Oh, and more innocent lives will be lost.”

“How cruel this world is,” he sighs, clutching a hand to his chest. “Between getting my in-laws’ approval and this accursed job market, will our love last…?”

Iris gestures for Mydei to lean down. “Lord Mydei, the *curse*…”

“I know.” He smiles. “But if I could be married to him, I’d take on it tenfold.”

“Sorry.” Phainon holds up a hand. “I’m delighted by the compliment, but what is this curse?”

Marsyas harrumphs. “Think we’d tell you? Info about the curse can only be passed to family members. Anyway, we still need a dowry. We’ll see what we can do after seeing what you can offer.”

Phainon wordlessly holds out two wrapped, slightly squashed honey suncakes from his pants pocket.

Livia gasps. “Mrs. Audata’s suncakes!”

Mydei finally interjects. “This should be enough, don’t you think? You five haven’t eaten lunch yet.”

“If His Highness allows it…” Marsyas says, eyes trailing the suncake.

“My in-laws are too heartless,” he mourns as Mydei begins splitting the pastries evenly amongst the children. “That’s all I have to my name.”

“Hmph.” Demetri nibbles on his portion. “I suppose this is enough. Alright, we’ll give you the information.”

“All this time and I just needed to bribe you guys?” He shakes his head in disbelief.

Livia pokes his arm. “Did you forget what I said in the beginning? No one says no to good food.”

“So all you need to do to settle things with bad in-laws is bribe them?”

“Maybe you could make the dish together as a bonding exercise.” Iris chews pensively. “But there are times where even that won’t work.”

“In that case, duel them!” Andriskos nods proudly.

“Do not,” Mydei chides. “Not unless they explicitly agree to it.”

As Phainon watches the scene unfold, he can’t help but think of the future. What did Caelus say? That Mydei was going to be married to make an heir? Biological or not, he just *knows* that one or two of those children are going to be just like Mydei, be it his looks or his mannerisms, and he *hates* that there’s not going to be a damn thing that he’s going to be able to do about it.

He turns to leave.

“Where are you going?”

He hesitantly turns back, because his body doesn’t listen to him otherwise.

Mydei stands with his arms crossed, eyes narrowed like Phainon had just tracked mud all over his clean floor.

He raises his nearly forgotten shirt feebly. “I was going to Aglaea because my shirt has a hole. Well, at least until you dragged me away and the kids ambushed us. You might want to check on them before they start doing cartwheels and pull a muscle or something.”

“They’ll be fine,” Mydei says quietly. “And I saved a bit for you, so stay a little longer.”

His chest aches at the request. “Saved? What of?”

He takes out a square of the suncake, holding it out to him, earnest and expecting something Phainon can no longer readily give him.

He only catches a glimpse of Mydei’s eyes widening and his mouth parting when he turns on his heel and darts away with the lingering feeling that he’s totally fucked.

Phainon stands outside of Aglaea’s office, looking down at the bag that holds his shirt and wincing. The blood for the most part had been scrubbed away, but there still was the problem of the gaping hole. He could theoretically try sewing it shut himself, but Aglaea always notices the difference right away when he does. So, he knocks.

“Come in,” Aglaea calls, and he shuffles in, imaginary tail between his legs in shame.

She pauses in her craft. “You’re back sooner than I anticipated.”

“Sorry to cause more trouble.” He takes out his (ruined) shirt and watches her take a pin out of her pincushion.

“No need to apologize. This happened all too many times when the Flame Chase was still going on and I’d rather have this happen now than during the ceremony. And…” He tries not to squirm when she stabs it through the stitches with deadly precision. “You’ve been acting rather odd as of late.”

“Is it that obvious?” he asks weakly.

She arches a perfect brow. “I can’t say for everyone, but I certainly have noticed, yes.”

“Sorry.” He forces a chuckle. “I didn’t mean to bring down the atmosphere —”

“Phainon,” she cuts. “Is this about the ceremony?”

“...Why is everyone assuming that?”

A Garmentmaker pulls out a chair for him to sit on. Aglaea primly says, “Perhaps you should reflect on why that is.”

He’s silent for approximately a second before he sits and mumbles, “Okay, I just don’t know why he has to rush into it, is all.”

“Rush?”

“The battle ended only months ago.” His voice is small. “He couldn’t think about it just a bit longer?”

Aglaea is silent for a while before she says, “While Mydeimos understands the importance of patience, it’s bound to run dry at some point. Do you not feel the same?”

“I do. I do to the point of ruin. But I can’t.” Phainon feels hysterical. “I can’t put down his happiness for the sake of mine. He doesn’t deserve it — he deserves someone better, someone who remembers his favorite foods, someone who would *dance* with him, for god’s sake, someone who can match up with him in every way, someone who is his *equal*—”

“—Someone who isn’t you?” She stares at him as if seeing through him, down to the deepest, ugliest parts of his soul. “All of those qualities you’ve listed are things that *you* are, things *you* know and things *you* do. Yet you go on to say that it can’t be you?”

“It can’t be me,” Phainon echoes, then a little more firmly, “Yes. It can’t be me. He doesn’t want me—he *can't* want me, even after everything I’ve done to him.”

“Then?” Aglaea’s gaze is a tad softer now. “What is your wish, Phainon?”

“I…” His fist clenches by his side. “I want the best for him.”

“‘For him’. I didn’t ask what you wanted for him. I asked what *you* wanted.” Her smile is faint but no less kind. “Tell me, Phainon, what is it that you want?”

He’s never had the leisure of thinking about what he wants. Every desire he’s had, every dream he once imagined, he had to swallow down every trace of them. He couldn’t afford a wish, not when everyone else had entrusted theirs to him.

“I don’t want anyone by his side but me,” he finally admits weakly. “Isn’t that too selfish of me?”

She shakes her head. “I think you can afford to be a little selfish.”

“But,” his voice cracks, growing smaller. “He deserves someone who can take pride in their feelings. Someone who wouldn’t be afraid to say they love him. Aglaea.” His smile shakes. “I hate how much I love him.”

Even so, he desperately wants.

The day of the ceremony arrives.

Aglaea has made wedding attire for all the Chrysos Heirs. They’re all intricately made, like she’s been waiting for the day she could finally use them.

“Mydeimos is getting ready in the other room,” she says while she helps him clip on an earring. In the middle shines a ruby. “Just about everyone has talked to him now. I think that he’d appreciate your words, no matter how short.” *Because you haven’t been talking to him recently* goes unsaid.

He exhales. “Right.”

She stares at him, then adjusts his choker. “I wish you happiness, Phainon. Even if it doesn’t work out the way you want it to.”

He offers her a smile. It isn’t the controlled, distant one Phainon the Deliverer uses. “Thank you.”

Like he’s preparing for battle, Phainon inhales and leaves, knocking gently on Mydei’s dressing room before pushing the door open.

“Hello?”

Phainon freezes, his fists clenching by his sides when he sees Mydei, in all his glory, blindfolded.

He's wearing the same clothes as last time, except now he has a folded strip of lacy fabric tangled with a golden laurel crown and tightly secured behind his head, dutifully covering his eyes. Phainon’s breath stops. A veil. A symbol of a wedding, no matter how wrinkled and creased it looks at the moment.

“Excuse me? Whoever just walked in.” Mydei fidgets with the knot at the back of his head. “Lady Tribios tied this around my eyes as a prank. I think it’s tangled with the laurel crown. She said it’s a wedding gift, so ripping it off seems rather rude, and it’s rather delicate. If you’re available, can you try to untie it for me?”

Wedding gift. Phainon's blood boils, tasting of hatred, of destruction. Then, he remembers he has no good reason to be angry, and the fresh wave of shame that floods him makes him want to vomit.

The footsteps he takes to reach Mydei echo far too loudly in the small dressing room. He stops just behind him, looking at Mydei's face in the mirror, then at himself. The cowlick that never goes down, the clothes Aglaea had painstakingly made for him, the eyebags that the girls will definitely want to slather some concealer over. He looks away, putting his hands on Mydei's shoulders.

His shoulders tense under his hands, though they relax far too quickly for Phainon's liking. *Oh, it's you,* the motion seems to say, and unreasonable jealousy wells up inside him again.

His voice won't come out of his throat. Perhaps it's better like this, that Mydei doesn't know it's him. He writes on Mydei's back with a trailing finger. *Are you nervous?*

"I think it's normal to be, on one's wedding day." Mydei smiles lightly. "But, it's my duty. For everyone's sake too."

You don't have to, he writes desperately, and that makes Mydei chuckle, something sweet and far more innocent than the usual smirks and scoffs he usually gives to Phainon, and he nearly collapses to his knees, when he sees it in the mirror.

Cyrene had kept her tarot cards in a box, he remembers. It was her treasure.

He wants to steal those smiles and short laughs before Mydei usually cuts himself off, like he didn't even deserve the luxury of laughing, and stuff them into a chest, not to be seen by anyone or anything but himself. The thought of stealing Mydei himself crosses his mind briefly.

He's heard of wedding customs in Castrum Kremnos, where the groom would come during the night to steal the bride away, carrying her back to his home. He thinks, for a moment, of scooping up Mydei into his arms and whisking him away, locking him up somewhere he couldn't be found. A room that would have a door that could withstand Mydei's might, with a quaint kitchen and a bed big enough for the two of them.

As if Mydei would allow himself to be stolen.

"I wanted this," Mydei admits quietly, as if he's almost too shy to reveal this revelation. Phainon's hand nearly ignites the wooden chair Mydei's sitting on. "I wanted… to be married to you. For a very long time now."

Phainon wishes, at this very moment, to the depths of his heart, that those words were meant for him. That these sweet words and equally sweet expressions were for him, and that after today, it would still be for him. That everything Mydei could offer, from his body, his voice, his words, his personality. He wanted all of it.

Everything around him, from the room to the decorations to Mydei himself, whispers to him to snap out of that sweet reverie. That this wedding wasn't meant for him. Nor will it ever be.

"My veil," Mydei reminds gently, and Phainon's fingers shake when they make contact with the fine lace.

His fingers caress the blond-red locks, playing with the braid as he lets the silky strands fall between the gaps of his fingers like sand. He's stalling.

Mydei makes a soft noise, as if to encourage him. Phainon's hands fall away completely. "What's wrong?"

This was no good. He selfishly, desperately, ardently wanted this man for himself.

He couldn't do this, not when this man had a lifetime of happiness in front of him, not when this man still had a kingdom to lead, least of all on this man's *wedding* day.

Mydei turns to him, or so the direction in which he believes Phainon is standing, reaching out a hand to him. He waits, hand steady and patient, and what can Phainon do but indulge him?

He takes his hand by the fingertips, guiding him to stand, and Mydei reaches out again, his fingers first scraping over his cheekbones, then after a few clumsy attempts, cups his face in his palm.

He’s not wearing his gauntlets, his hands bare, though his tattoos still whirl around them, one in particular curling around his finger like a ring. Like a promise.

Who are you doing this for, Phainon wants to ask, even as he pushes his face to nuzzle Mydei’s hand. *Who are you being this tender for, who are you being this vulnerable for, who put that look on your face?*

“Take me,” Mydei murmurs suddenly, soft as lace. “Whisk me away.”

His breath, betraying him, catches. He shakily writes on his arm, *Will that be okay?*

Mydei’s laugh is brighter than the sun. “Why wouldn’t it be? It’s our wedding day, after all.”

He doesn’t let his face crumple when he hears the word *our*. He closes his eyes, letting his lashes sweep over Mydei’s fingertips, and crashes through the window to take flight to steal the bride.

Phainon has long known that Lady Tribios was a lady of miraculous feats, and apparently one of them seems to be that they have magic hands. Throughout the entire flight back to his quarters, the lace knot had not loosened in the least.

Mydei, for some reason, had shown little surprise at the sudden shatter of a window and the wind whistling next to their ears, only slotting his head in the crook of his neck and pressing closer when the breeze got too strong.

While Phainon had indeed given in and taken (read: kidnapped) Mydei from the venue, he hadn't quite thought it through. What could he even gain from this? Delaying the inevitable ceremony by how many hours? How could this make a difference this late into the game? Where was he even taking them?

As he soars across Okhema, he finally realizes where he’s headed.

The Chrysos Heirs’ quarters.

He lands just outside, still carrying Mydei all the while as his wings fold back into him (though leaving another two conspicuous holes in his clothes yet again). Janus’s door creaks before swinging open. The first one on the left is Mydei’s room; the mechanism spinning open in the presence of its owner.

Phainon's eyes skate over the state of the room as he strides in; scrolls strewn this way and that, the kitchen impeccable as always, a felt doll from Castorice.

When he reaches the bedroom, he deposits Mydei onto the bed, and heads back for the door. What else can he do?

"...You're leaving?" Mydei asks, and he stops, helpless as always. There's something like… a *pout* on his lips as he adds too innocently, "On our wedding night?"

Phainon gnaws on his lip until he tastes the metal tang of blood as he stalks back to his bedside. What does he *want?* For his restraint to wear thin? For his brain to deteriorate enough to think that kissing Mydei right now until they both can hardly breathe still feels like a good idea?

Well, Phainon will readily forfeit this, for both things have already happened.

His lips graze the back of Mydei's hand. He doesn't pull away right away, scanning Mydei's face for his reaction.

"Not there." Mydei's smile is teasing. Goading him.

Helpless yet again, Phainon kisses his cheek, just over his tattoo.

“Try again.” His cheeks are flushed now, but his lips don't get any less tempting.

Ah. His Primum Mobile was never restraint. Phainon has always been entirely too reckless, too impatient for things he truly treasured.

The kiss is soft, almost chaste. Of a secret, of a looming threat that if Phainon can delude himself so, Mydei is his for the night. And never again. He must remind himself to not be greedy. To hold back his desires, no matter the cost. To not take too much, because Mydei deserves that much, at the very least.

He takes Mydei’s hand again, brushing his lips over the tattoo that looks too much like a ring to be anything else at this point. It’ll be covered within the week, he thinks. By whatever ring that bastard proposed to him with, probably.

“You’re a little warm,” Mydei murmurs as he pulls Phainon on top of his body. He startles; his knee slots between Mydei’s legs and his elbows brackets his head. “Are you feeling alright?”

Phainon lifts their joined hands to his forehead, his bangs tickling Mydei as he nods against his fingers, willing his skin to cool rapidly.

Look what you did. He's worrying about you again, he chastises himself. *Don’t take too much, and don’t give away too much.*

“Then, one more time.” Mydei holds his head in his hands, thumbs absentmindedly tracing over his face.

Over his eyelids, as Phainon tries to keep them open to sear this scene to memory.

Over his nose, which has always been slightly crooked after he had tripped and fell face-first during his childhood.

Over his earlobes, where he shivers and digs his chin into Mydei’s chest.

Over his lips, where Phainon gives in, like too many other times today, to dip his head and press their lips together.

(He despairs.)

Mydei tips his head, arching up to meet him. His hands rove over his chest, his shoulders, and eventually slide to his choker, his fingers scratching lightly over his nape.

Phainon desperately prays that the noise he hears is not his.

His mouth falls open on a gasp, allowing Mydei a chance to lick the open seam of his lips. He tastes a smile that sits prettily on the corners of Mydei's lips that fades when he pulls away, feeling entirely too feverish.

"Open your mouth," Mydei demands, only it sounds too breathless to be properly authoritative.

So Phainon obeys, attempting and failing to hide his rapacity that lurks in every action. His tongue licks into Mydei's mouth until saliva trickles down both their chins and each intermittent breaths are stuck together. He blinks rapidly, as if his eyelids were a camera's shutter, wanting each and every sound and face Mydei makes to be encased on film. His hand caresses down his face, forcing Mydei's jaw higher into a better angle; the other tangles into Mydei's hair with enough strength that he *knows* should be too harsh, but Mydei gives a faint whine that's muffled against his own lips when he tugs.

The noise makes Phainon pull away, panting and looking down at Mydei with swollen lips and too-wide pupils and a nagging feeling that this whole situation felt *wrong*.

Was this what he wanted? How long could he hold up this charade? How could he do this to Mydei, betraying his trust yet *again?*

(Why was there still a sick sense of glee, some part of him that relishes the fact that *he* was the one who caused this, that *he* was the one who put that expression on Mydei's face, that in this moment, Mydei wanted *him?*)

As if he could sense his hesitation, Mydei kicks his back with a heel, jolting him back. "Don't overthink it. Come at me with everything you have, all of the best parts of you and all of the ugliest. I want them all, down to the tiniest bit."

Phainon breaks. He goes slow at first, leaning down until his breath ghosts over Mydei's flesh. Using a finger, he pulls his necklace to the side, feigning gentleness until his teeth close over Mydei's skin, beads of blood blooming over his tongue as he licks and sucks and bites down with increasing fervor, over and over again as he trails across Mydei's neck and chest, the indents creating constellations in his wake.

Mydei writhes in his grasp, his hands grappling his shirt until the threads nearly tear. He makes a high sound deep in his throat, oscillating between pushing him away ("Too much, too *much*—") and pulling him closer (he doesn't say anything when he does, just pulls Phainon's collar and bares his neck, trembling when Phainon bites down, a content sigh to reward him when he laps up the blood, eager to not even let a drop escape).

Phainon's hand pushes down Mydei's robes past his shoulder, leaving a scattered pool of red and white fabric on the bed as he marks up the other half of his body.

"Oil—" Mydei rasps between whimpers and shivers. "In the drawer—"

It’s only now when Phainon finally withdraws that he notices the bulges—namely, his, which he had known about, and Mydei’s, which twitches when he roughly thumbs over it.

If he does this, there’s truly no going back.

“...Husband?” But when he hears the soft siren call of Mydei’s voice, the smattering of bites spread across Mydei’s neck and torso, the flushed allure of Mydei’s cheeks, he is reminded that no matter how close he may be to a demigod, a Titan, or maybe something more than that, he is only a man.

He pulls open the drawer, the contents clattering when he pulls it open with too much force and grabs the small, conspicuous vial. He presses the cool glass to Mydei’s calf, letting him know of its existence and moves to unplug it.

Mydei catches his arm with deadly precision, to the point Phainon has to check to make sure the blindfold hasn’t been loosened. “Wait.”

Ice freezes his limbs, too contrary to the fire that bubbles in his veins, as he realizes slowly but surely… Ah. Of course. He should’ve known that Mydei would find out and he’d be regarded with revulsion by the one person he wishes to have to himself, who knows and understands him as his kindred spirit—

“Your clothes. Take them off,” Mydei says as he takes the bottle from him. Phainon exhales as relief floods him. He hasn’t been caught. Not yet.

He struggles against his clothes in his haste, carelessly discarding them as he thinks, in disbelief, that he’s so close to getting what he’s wanted for millions of cycles.

When the light hits his eyes again, he’s greeted to the sight of Mydei’s legs splayed open, leaving nothing to the imagination as he works himself open. His taint glistens with oil as his fingers piston inside and out, breathing into Phainon’s coat that he hadn’t fully thrown on the floor.

Phainon’s hands move before he thinks; he spreads Mydei’s legs wider, kneading his inner thighs. Mydei’s flesh under his palms is soft, and he pinches it before he shoves a finger into his hole, desperate to pull some kind, any kind of reaction from Mydei.

A soft, punched out noise is elicited. Mydei squirms and turns away at the addition of another finger, biting down on his lip and looking extremely aggrieved as he quiets.

Phainon leans down, lips against his neck as he mouths three desperate words into his skin. *Don’t keep quiet.*

He doesn’t know if the words register, but he curls his fingers, yet is only bestowed with nails slipping on his forearms, feebly trying to scratch at him. That’s okay, he’ll take what he can get.

It’s only when he starts pumping his fingers in earnest that finally, *finally*, Mydei opens his mouth, hitching around a ragged breath, and moans directly in his ear so wantonly that Phainon flinches and bucks his hips against his body.

He sounds like he’s being fucked.

Phainon tries to shake the thought away, but his brain, traitorous as always, tells him that *this* is the face Mydei would make. *These* are the noises he would make.

And they are not his. They belong to a different man, a man he doesn’t know, a man Mydei trusts and allows for them to do these things with.

He twists his hand to press down on Mydei’s insides, savoring the keen as he does so, and slips his hand out, his digits slick with oil and fluids. He thinks of tasting it, his tongue leaden as he strokes down Mydei’s flank, across the numerous bites and his nipples and his crimson tattoos.

Mydei’s body seizes, his hands flying up with a sudden strength to claw down his shoulder blades, baring blood to the light. He barely blinks at the pain, watching with a heavy intensity as Mydei cries and grips onto him like a lifeline while he comes between their stomachs.

All of a sudden, Phainon aches to see his eyes, wants to see his expression when he sees it's Phainon, not whoever he's getting married to, wants to see and be seen, but keeps his hands still on his waist, allowing him time to recover.

Mydei himself, however, does not seem to approve of this decision. He trails down to Phainon's hands with his own shaky ones, and places one on his cheek, the other on his chest. Phainon tries very hard not to gulp audibly. "What, now that you've had a taste, you've had enough? I thought you'd last longer than this."

Mydei gropes at him, and Phainon jerks into the circle of his palm, staring through blurry eyes at the curve of his lips, smug in his knowledge of Phainon's crumbling self control.

Please, he implores on Mydei's collarbone, his tongue laving over the divots of his previous bites. He can't say it aloud, so he kisses his pleas over and over into his skin. If his words burned into flesh like ink, it would be all over Mydei's body by now, weaving along the red swirls.

"Please?" Mydei parrots, voice teeming with self satisfaction. He still looks arrogant somehow, even with dried saliva at the corner of his mouth and the marks adorning him like a second necklace. "Please what? Speak properly."

Phainon grinds his teeth, sucking a new bruise on his chest as he imagines fucking into Mydei like this, to see his loftiness falter and his face lost in pleasure. To see him shake as his hole leaks a mess of fluids, some

concoction of their bodies, as Mydei alternates somewhere between pushing him away from overstimulation, eyes glistening with unshed tears, and pulling him closer for more, trying to meld their bodies together.

But, he says nothing. Phainon simply nudges himself against his entrance, pulling away when Mydei tries to force it through, begging once against the corner of Mydei's lips, and repeats.

"You—HKS!" He shoves against Phainon's shoulder, even when his legs wrap around his hips. "If you're going to do it, then do it properly! Don't dawdle around for my permission and just *take* it—"

Phainon had wanted to go slow. He wanted to take their time together, adjust when needed, and connect their bodies together into something primal but beautiful.

Mydei chokes when Phainon slams himself in.

Phainon opens his mouth to say something; somewhere along their usual jabs, but all he can think of is how *pretty* Mydei looks, speared on his cock like this, and how *good* he feels, clenching wetly over him, twitching and squeezing and trying to suck in him in more.

He presses a quick kiss to Mydei's jaw, and gives another experimental thrust, stars sparking in the corner of his vision, as he reverently trails his fingers over the lace.

Mydei thrashes, his moan bordering on a scream and his hands nearly ripping apart the sheets as his cock leaks over his stomach.

Phainon runs his hands and lips all over his body; he can't help himself. He brushes back Mydei's hair from his lips and tucks it behind his ear, reminiscent of their dance. He brings Mydei's limp hand to his lips, kissing each of his fingers. A ring for each one, the promise one sided. He sucks a mark under Mydei's jaw, just to make it harder to find, and perhaps if he's lucky, it'll stay for longer. He hovers longer than he should've over Mydei's lips, eventually turning away to affectionately peck from cheek to cheek.

When he's done, Mydei is flushed down to his chest, his mouth parted and words slurred. "Enough. At least let me return the favor."

Phainon obediently leans down, albeit terribly entertained by him wanting to repay in kind. He shudders when Mydei sloppily mouths his earlobe and caresses down the length of his back, until he reaches where Phainon's tenth thoracic vertebrae is, whimpering softly when Mydei chuckles and smooths away his bangs from his sweaty forehead.

His amusement is cut short when Phainon fucks back into him as he swipes a thumb over Mydei's lips and mouths prayers with his own as he tries not to go too hard.

Oronyx, lift the curtain of memory and stir up ripples of past reverie.

Nikador, calamity eternal, casting devastation on myriad cities, turn foes to ash.

Kephale, through your divine visage, holiness is revealed and the beautiful dawn arrives.

Mnestia—

His thoughts are ripped away with an involuntary gasp; Mydei grinds down on him, meeting each of his thrusts like he wants them to pierce through him, fingertips light on his stomach like he's feeling the way Phainon's cock moves inside him.

Phainon lifts them into a sitting position, Mydei sighing as he's inched down and his cock drools against Phainon's stomach. He stares up at Mydei, his chin on Mydei's chest as Mydei's mouth moves, but nothing comes out. Oh. A name he can't read.

He drives Mydei's hips down to meet his thighs, harsh enough for Mydei to forget whoever he's calling for as his mouth lolls open.

Even when I'm here, trying to fuck a baby into you, you still think of another.

He bites down on one of Mydei's nipples, sucking it until it's sensitive and swollen and Mydei's keening and trying to turn away. Phainon wraps a possessive hand over his waist and uses the other to stroke lightly under the lace blindfold, teasing him with light.

Mydei jerks in his hold, spilling over their stomachs with a strangled sob and hands pushing against his shoulder like he can't bear the onslaught of pleasure.

Phainon doesn't stop, his pace a punishment as it morphs from give to *take*, a wolf shedding its sheep's clothing. He ravages at the seam of Mydei's lips until he blearily opens, nipping at his lip with a ferocity until the flavor of Mydei's blood colors his tongue.

Mydei messily presses back a kiss to the corner of Phainon's lips, peppering them across his face like stars. Adoringly, like he is loved.

"Husband," Mydei mumbles against his neck, smearing wet over his sun tattoo. "Please—just a bit slower—"

But the flame of selfishness has already been lit. *Bear with it,* he mouths into Mydei's pulse, looking at him through his lashes as he marks his way down the column of his throat.

Mydei's head throws back as he thrusts with reckless abandon, and Phainon catches him by his weak spot when his body sways back. Mydei's mouth

shapes a soundless moan, around a name he can't read. The same one as before.

Phainon seethes, emotion overtaking him.

Why couldn't it have been *his* name Mydei cried out for? Why couldn't it be *him* that Mydei turned to and smiled like he hung the moon and stars?

Why couldn't it have been *him?*

The words tumble out before he can reel them in fast enough. "I wish you thought of this as much as I have," he chokes aloud. "I wish you wanted this as much as I do. I wish you thought of me, instead of him."

I wish you loved me, selfishly. Not just in this cycle, but in all of them.

Under his body, Mydei turns rigid, then sluggishly pushes against his chest. "Let go."

Phainon clings on tighter, trying to bury himself into the crook of his neck so he doesn't have to face his disappointment, but Mydei makes an impatient noise, struggling, not as hard as Phainon knows he can, though whether it's from his climax or something else, he doesn't know. "Phainon, let go."

So he knows. He knows?

Numb, Phainon sits back on his haunches, scrubbing at his face, saltwater clinging to his lashes. To his horror, Mydei starts to tug down the makeshift blindfold, the knot having come halfway undone.

Panic wraps its icy hands around his neck, puncturing the breath from his lungs, and he nearly launches himself off the bed in his haste, pleasure forgotten.

He knows.

“Phainon.” He hears a growl, when he’s got one foot on the floor and about to pick up his jacket, which had slipped down to the floor. “If you leave this room right now, don’t even *think* about seeing me again.”

The heavy feeling of dread seizes his bones, settling along his spine as his body slowly sits him back on the bed. He stares down at the space just past Mydei’s feet, unable to look up.

“I’m sorry,” Phainon hears himself mutter under his breath, fast and quiet and wrong. “I’m sorry I took advantage of you, when you thought it was him, when you wanted *him.* I’m sorry, I’m sorry, I was wrong.”

I’m sorry that I even thought that I could have you, even for a second.

“Phainon,” Mydei commands, and underneath the weight of his gaze, Phainon flinches, bracing for rejection. There's a short pause, then a sigh. A thumb caresses under his eye, gathering tears. “What are you crying for?”

His voice is unbearably gentle, like they’re back in the dressing room, and Phainon wants to rake his nails along his skin, to create scratches and wounds and make himself bleed and dry out as compensation. His vision goes blurrier, his head tilting to give better access for Mydei’s hand.

“I’m not crying,” he still insists, stubborn.

The bed creaks until Mydei sits right in front of him, until Phainon can see the dips of his knees.

“Look at me,” Mydei demands. “Face me, for the man I chose as my husband should not be this cowardly.”

Slowly, Phainon looks up.

Mydei’s lashes are clumped together with tears, lips bitten red in his attempts to keep silent. His eyes are clear, his mouth set, not quite angry,

more so determined. He’s red as if he’s fevered, and paintings of Phainon’s bites decorate his torso like he’s been mauled.

He's the most beautiful that Phainon’s ever seen him.

He wipes his eyes. “How did you know it was me?”

Mydei scoffs, pinching his cheek. “How could I not know? I know what your hands feel like on my body. I know how it feels when you look at me. I’ve heard you pant in my ear, worn out from spars and battles alike. So perhaps the question is why you can’t believe that I’ve known it was you all along.”

But something sticks to him when he recalls what Mydei had said, echoing in the chambers of his brain. “...Husband?”

Mydei tilts his head, looking rather disgruntled but otherwise attentive. “Yes?”

“No,” he scrambles to say. “I wasn’t calling you my husband, even though I’d really like to—I just—sorry, what do you mean *I’m* the one you chose?”

Mydei’s eyes slowly grow wide, then narrow. “Phainon,” he says very carefully. “Were you not aware that I wanted to do the ceremony with you?”

Ceremony? But—are they talking about the same thing?

"What," he says weakly.

"The ceremony," he elaborates in disbelief. "The mock ceremony Aglaea set up?"

Phainon's mouth feels like cotton when he moves it to ask, "Mock…?"

"Phainon." Mydei looks like he cannot believe how stupid he is. "Did you think I was genuinely getting married? To someone *else* at that?"

"I—" He looks away, hangdog fashion. "No one told me otherwise."

Mydei grips the sides of his head, forcing him back to face him and his full glare. "Then ask *me*. Oh gods—is this why you've been avoiding me?"

"It may have a slight correlation to it," he says meekly.

Mydei groans. "You—okay. Aglaea said she wanted to make clothes for a wedding for a long time now, being the demigod of Romance and all. She

asked me if we could hold a mock ceremony."

"Why'd she ask you and not… Lady Tribios?" *Or anyone other than you, preferably.*

He sighs, pinching Phainon's cheek again. "I asked her what she thought about marriage for my kingdom, politically speaking. As a former political leader and as the demigod of Romance, I thought it best to ask her. She offered me a deal; advice in exchange for the mock ceremony. I thought it was a fair exchange; if anything, I was gaining far more than her. So we went through with the motions, just to see how it'd go and sort of like a test round to see if this was something I might want."

"So you're still getting married?" Phainon takes his hand, wilting. "You're getting a political marriage?"

"Did I say that?" Mydei huffs. "Let me tell you something, Phainon. I had one condition that I wanted in order to proceed with the ceremony. I wanted *you* to play the part as my groom."

"Then, if it was fake, why did you rile me up by calling me…" he trails off, unable to continue.

Mydei blinks, then says far too innocently to be real, "What? Husband?"

Phainon blushes. “It doesn’t matter anyway.”

“It does.” Mydei softens. His fingers start to draw away, and Phainon latches onto them with a fervor that belongs to a mad man.

“Phainon,” he says, and it’s so fond, too fond, that Phainon has to close his eyes and remember how to breathe. “What is it that you want?”

“Be my husband?” Phainon asks, breathless. “For real this time?”

He scoffs. “Take me out for a date first and I’ll think about it.”

They fall back onto the bed and as Phainon’s bangs fall over his eyes, Mydei brushes them back, grinning like he’s on the battlefield. “Your hair’s getting longer.”

Their lips collide together into a bruising crash just as Phainon snaps up his hips hard. The scream Mydei makes is devoured, and he spasms violently against him, clenching down tight as Phainon releases in him.

When Phainon pulls back, a translucent string of their saliva remains in between their bodies.

As his eyes rove over Mydei’s hazy eyes, his slack mouth, his chest, they tell him that this is *real*, even so, he begs. “Look at me, and tell me it’s not

him you see, but me."

"I've been wondering for a while but," Mydei's head lolls against his shoulder as aftershocks spark through him, "Who's—*ah*—him?"

"I don't know," he sniffs. "Just—I thought that you were getting together with someone from the Kremnoan Detachment because I couldn't figure out who you were going to marry. I know you were close with them, and I didn't know who else—"

Mydei's laugh is bright when he kisses his cheek. "I'll introduce you to them some time."

"Okay…"

Mydei sucks a bruise in the middle of his tattoo, clenching down tight, and Phainon finds himself unable to remember what he was going to say next.

As he goes dizzy with pleasure, the allure a tempest he's getting far too swept up into to get out of, he hears three words, sweet and laid bare like the man in his lap.

"I love you."

Three simple words.

Those three, simple words were enough for Phainon's thoughts to come to a screeching halt.

His first thought when he recovers is, *he must be lying.*

Then he looks at Mydei, expression soft and vulnerable, and a seed of hope traitorously burrows its way into his heart. His second thought moves his lips. *I want it to be true.* His voice comes out pitifully small. "Really?" He leans closer, until they're chest to chest and there's the tiniest flicker of unrestrained pleasure that flits across Mydei's face when he shifts their bodies. "Really? Truly?"

"Yes," he replies, sounding entirely too affectionate. Phainon wants to drown in it. "I love you."

Phainon shifts again, circling his hips until Mydei throws his head back against the pillows, gasping. "Please—say it again," he begs, desperation working into his voice. "Again. Just a few more—no, just once more is enough. *Please*."

"Phainon." A hand rests on his cheek. An indulgent, breathtaking smile. "There's no need to rush anymore. I'll say it as many times as you'll like." A kiss on his brow, where his eyebrows are drawn together in distraught. His temple, where his head throbs with tension. The corners of his eyes, where it is undoubtedly tear-stained.

Then, his world flips, his gaze meeting Mydei's ceiling.

"And if you still don't believe it," Mydei bears down, smile triumphant, "I'll just have to say it until you do."

"Ah—please—"

Mydei grabs his face, turning it from side to side. "So *this* was what I was missing with the blindfold on. Not a bad view."

"Mydei," he croaks, putting his beloved's name into the world, no longer afraid of reality. "Mydei, Mydei, Mydei, *please.*"

"More." His voice is scraped raw, yet his grin is ferally majestic, and something in Phainon's chest breaks, cracks spiderwebbing in his core as he can only obey, giving and giving until he has nothing left.

"The room is empty, Agy." Tribbie flits over the broken glass. "Sheesh. Couldn't Snowy have left through the door?"

She looks up at Aglaea, who steps delicately over the glass. “Is it alright that our grooms just got stolen? We all worked so hard for the ceremony, especially you.”

“If the other result was them dancing around each other for another thirty million cycles, then I would rather it turn out like it did.” A thin string of gold pools from her wrist and down to the floor, collecting the shards. “As everyone else would, I believe.”

“Hmm…if you’re sure! *We* were looking forward to being flower girls, though.”

“Don’t worry.” She looks out the window, her eyes glinting. “I’d say we’ll be busy with another wedding soon enough.”

End Notes

i love them sm they make me so ill (i caught the stomach flu 3 days after i started writing this). anyway I wrote u drilling mydei into the mattress so pls come home e6 phainon. Happy pride month!

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